



Born in the spiritual town of Nabadwip Dham in West Bengal, Aloknath had the influence of holy men on him from a very young age. Even though his family migrated to Kolkata soon after he turned a year old, Aloknath credits his birthplace for teaching him the lessons of renunciation, finding fulfillment in life, and cherishing it.

Aloknath's father picked up his LLB degree out of passion while working as a gazetted officer at the Food Corporation of India. Under his tutelage, Aloknath was home-schooled till the age of six. A rigorous man, it was he who built the strong foundation of science and mathematics for Aloknath.

Aloknath recalls, "He was a very disciplined person, and he influenced my love for science. So, taking up science after 10th standard was a very natural choice." Aloknath went to a proper school only when he was in the 2nd standard. While home-schooling provided him with the basic skills, he gained 'interactive intelligence' only after he went to school.

Aloknath says, "I realised that natural intelligence, or the ability to react in a situation, comes only when you interact and talk with more and more people. The more you converse, the more you grow."

Aloknath's mother, a homemaker, has always been soft-natured. She is an epitome of love and affection. This fusion of hard and soft behaviour of parents is what Aloknath tries to maintain in his own life as well, even today. In fact, his leadership mantra is: "Be Hard on Goal, Be Soft on Soul."

Diligent from childhood, it was quite natural for Aloknath to be a topper in his school. But by the time he was in 6th standard, a sense of restlessness loomed over him. "It gave me a feeling of accomplishment in the beginning, but then it made me feel as if I was not being

A Few Lessons from Dr Aloknath De's Story

- ABC of Achievement—Align (your thoughts), Beam (your energy), Collaborate (your ecosystem)
- Infuse lateral thinking, when needed, before making decisions rationally
- Keep your mind open to learning new things; continuous learning is of essence
- Get out of your comfort zone; perturb a bit when too comfortable. Bring stability from comfort zone and growth from outside the comfort zone
- Building zero-to-one has different challenge than scaling one-to-infinity
- What is interesting about life is that sometimes taking an apparent step back can help you leap forward by ten steps
- Your unique way of doing and supporting will always be valued by the community

challenged enough." This notion of not ever getting too comfortable in something was a lesson that has driven Aloknath all through his life.

On the lookout for more competition to raise his accomplishment bar, Aloknath decided to appear for a Central government merit scholarship programme, which allowed him to study in a residential school of his choice. And he got admission in Ramakrishna Mission (RKM) Residential School in Purulia—a district 250km away from Kolkata.

Though he had the option to choose a school in Kolkata and stay near his family, Aloknath decided not to base his choice on emotions, and rather grab the opportunity to live and operate independently. The pangs of separation from his parents and siblings struck him in the initial phase. But Aloknath knew that he was accountable for the decision that he had taken and that he had to stick to it—a lesson that he would recall again, years later.

Although his father was a strong influence in his life, it was his monk headmaster at RKM whom Aloknath regards as his role model. "He was a man of such purity. He had mastery over multiple languages. Once I was writing an essay about the river Ganges. I showed him the first draft and he helped me make it better—his knowledge was profound. I would say it was the best piece in Bengali that I have ever written."

It is not surprising that science

and math were his favourite subjects. But Aloknath was not excellent in academics alone, he also took active part in school debates, elocutions, recitation competitions, and so on. He even appeared on numerous TV debate shows broadcast by Doordarshan.

A rational thinker since childhood, Aloknath quickly figured out that his heart lay in engineering. When he was in the 11th standard, he decided to share this with his father, who was then disappointed with his decision. "My father wanted to be a doctor, but it was not possible due to financial constraints. He was hoping that I would become a physician, but I chose engineering. I remember it was a long-drawn evening discussion with my father and uncle. They tried very hard to change my mind."

Aloknath did not budge from his goal and readied himself to prepare for the next chapter in his life.

IIT and finding his calling

A large chunk of Aloknath's future plans began taking shape in his undergraduate years that he spent at IIT Kharagpur. While studying Electronics and Communication Engineering (ECE), he remained a high-achiever here too. Having done his secondary education in a Bengali-medium school, the fluency with which some students at IIT spoke English alarmed him. But he did not let it intimidate him. He